PADHAKU
First Flight · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 9

The Proposal

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ The Proposal · Before You Read

1 **The word ‘proposal’ has several meanings. Can you guess what sort of proposal the play is about? (i) a suggestion, plan or scheme for doing something (ii) an offer for a possible plan or action (iii) the act of asking someone’s hand in marriage**

✔ ANSWER

(iii) the act of asking someone’s hand in marriage.

In the play Lomov comes to Chubukov’s house to ask for the hand of his daughter Natalya in marriage.

2 **Do you think Indian and Russian weddings have any customs in common? With the help of a partner, fill in the table below: Wedding Ceremonies in Russia and India – Customs similar to Indian ones / Customs different from Indian ones.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Customs similar to Indian ones	Customs different from Indian ones
Both families share the expenses (earlier the bride’s family paid)	The wedding is registered (marriage registration) instead of religious rituals like pheras

The wedding lasts for days and is a big celebration	The groom must answer questions/riddles at every landing to reach the bride
A procession (baraat) goes with the groom	After registration the couple goes on a city tour before the reception
The bride's friends tease the groom and ask for money (like 'joota chupai' – stealing the groom's shoes)	Toasts are raised with wine and the groom kisses the bride in public
Friends and relatives make speeches, play games and enjoy a reception	The groom's friends 'steal' the bride and he pays a fee to get her back

🤔 The Proposal · Thinking about the Play

1 **What does Chubukov at first suspect that Lomov has come for? Is he sincere when he later says "And I've always loved you, my angel, as if you were my own son"? Find reasons for your answer from the play.**

✔ ANSWER

At first Chubukov suspects that Lomov has come **to borrow money**. He says aside, "He's come to borrow money. Shan't give him any!"

He is **not sincere** when he later says he has always loved Lomov like his own son:

- His words change only when he learns that Lomov wants to marry Natalya. He is glad because Lomov is a rich neighbour and the marriage makes good economic sense; he also wants his 25-year-old daughter settled.
- Soon after, in the quarrel over Oxen Meadows, he calls Lomov a “pettifogger”, “malicious, doublefaced intriguer”, “blind hen”, “turnip-ghost”, “stuffed sausage” and orders him never to set foot in his house again.
- At the end he says, “Hurry up and get married and — well, to the devil with you!... Only leave me in peace!”

So his affection is only a show of politeness and self-interest.

2 **Chubukov says of Natalya: “... as if she won’t consent! She’s in love; egad, she’s like a lovesick cat...” Would you agree? Find reasons for your answer.**

✔ ANSWER

Yes, I agree to a large extent, though she is more eager to get married than truly in love.

- Natalya is 25 and her father wants her married; Lomov is a rich neighbour, a suitable match.
- She quarrels with Lomov over Oxen Meadows only because she does not know why he has come.

- The moment her father tells her that Lomov came to propose, she falls into a chair and wails, “Bring him back! Back!... I’m dying! Fetch him!” and has hysterics.
- She quickly gives up her claim: “Oxen Meadows... really are yours.” When he faints and comes round she at once says, “Yes, yes, I’m willing” and “I’m happy too.”

This shows she is very keen to marry Lomov, as her father says.

3 (i) **Find all the words and expressions in the play that the characters use to speak about each other, and the accusations and insults they hurl at each other. (For example, Lomov in the end calls Chubukov an intriguer; but earlier, Chubukov has himself called Lomov a “malicious, doublefaced intriguer.” Again, Lomov begins by describing Natalya as “an excellent housekeeper, not bad-looking, well-educated.”)**

✔ ANSWER

Chubukov about/to Lomov: my dear fellow, my darling, my angel, my treasure, my precious, my beauty, (loved) as if you were my own son, young man, pettifogger, “All your people were like that”, “You Lomovs have had lunacy in your family”, your grandfather was a drunkard, your father was a guzzling gambler, intriguer, malicious, doublefaced intriguer, villain, scarecrow, “Devil take him!”, blind hen, turnip-ghost, stuffed sausage, wizen-faced frump, boy, pup, fool, milksop, “you’re under the slipper of your house-keeper”, “You’re not a hunter at all”.

Natalya about/to Lomov: good neighbour, a friend (earlier), impudent, “behave to us as if we were gypsies”, a rascal, a monster, “demon of contradiction in you”, “those hunters argue most who know least”, “What sort of a hunter are you?”, “go and lie on the kitchen oven and catch black beetles”, “You can’t even sit on a horse!”; his aunt was a backbiter.

Lomov about/to Chubukov: honoured Stepan Stepanovitch, grabber, “not a neighbour”, your grandfather was tried for embezzlement, your mother was hump-backed, intriguer, old rat, Jesuit, “your late wife used to beat you”.

Lomov about/to Natalya: an excellent housekeeper, not bad-looking, well-educated; honoured Natalya Stepanovna; madam; “you consider me either blind or a fool”.

About Lomov himself: Lomov calls himself "excitable" and says he suffers from palpitations; Chubukov says he is "just on the look-out for a chance to go to court".

3 (ii) Then think of five adjectives or adjectival expressions of your own to describe each character in the play.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **Chubukov:** selfish, hypocritical, short-tempered, quarrelsome, materialistic (money-minded).
- **Natalya:** argumentative, proud, hot-headed, eager to marry, practical (a good housekeeper).
- **Lomov:** nervous, hypochondriac (always complaining of his health), suspicious, quarrelsome, indecisive.

3 (iii) Can you now imagine what these characters will quarrel about next?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

They are quarrelsome by nature and fight over petty things, so they will quarrel again and again, for example about:

- whether Guess or Squeezer is the better dog (they are already fighting about it at the end);
- the wedding: date, guests, dowry, expenses and arrangements;

- who owns which piece of land, the crops, hay or the threshing-machine;
- each other's families and relatives, household matters and hunting.

🤔 The Proposal · Thinking about Language

I.1 **This play has been translated into English from the Russian original. Are there any expressions or ways of speaking that strike you as more Russian than English? For example, would an adult man be addressed by an older man as my darling or my treasure in an English play? Read through the play carefully, and find expressions that you think are not used in contemporary English, and contrast these with idiomatic modern English expressions that also occur in the play.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Expressions that sound Russian / not used in contemporary English:

- my darling, my angel, my treasure, my precious, my beauty, my beloved, dear one (said by one man to another)
- honoured Stepan Stepanovitch, honoured Natalya Stepanovna
- thanks to your prayers; egad; By Jove; Tfoo!; Ouf!
- I'll give it to them in the neck!; Be hanged to your Squeezer!; Kiss and be damned to you!

- turnip-ghost, wizen-faced frump, stuffed sausage, blind hen
- under the slipper of your house-keeper; lie on the kitchen oven and catch black beetles

Idiomatic modern English expressions in the play:

- Don't go round and round it! Spit it out!
- I can't make head or tail of all this
- Why talk rot?; shout yourself hoarse
- He seems to be coming round; My foot's gone to sleep
- What a weight off my shoulders!; want to have me on; It's an open secret; ran neck-and-neck

I.2 **Look up the following words in a dictionary and find out how to pronounce them. Pay attention to how many syllables there are in each word, and find out which syllable is stressed, or said more forcefully.**
palpitations, interfere, implore, thoroughbred, pedigree, principle, evidence, misfortune, malicious, embezzlement, architect, neighbours, accustomed, temporary, behaviour, documents

✔ ANSWER

(Stressed syllable in CAPITALS)

Word	Syllables	Stress
palpitations	pal-pi-TA-tions (4)	3rd

interfere	in-ter-FERE (3)	3rd
implore	im-PLORE (2)	2nd
thoroughbred	THO-rough-bred (3)	1st
pedigree	PED-i-gree (3)	1st
principle	PRIN-ci-ple (3)	1st
evidence	EV-i-dence (3)	1st
misfortune	mis-FOR-tune (3)	2nd
malicious	ma-LI-cious (3)	2nd
embezzlement	em-BEZ-zle-ment (4)	2nd
architect	AR-chi-tect (3)	1st
neighbours	NEIGH-bours (2)	1st
accustomed	ac-CUS-tomed (3)	2nd
temporary	TEM-po-ra-ry (4)	1st
behaviour	be-HAV-iour (3)	2nd
documents	DOC-u-ments (3)	1st

I.3 **Look up the following phrases in a dictionary to find out their meaning, and then use each in a sentence of your own. (i) You may take it that (ii) He seems to be coming round (iii) My foot's gone to sleep**

✔ ANSWER

(i) You may take it that – you can be sure / accept as true that.

Sentence: You may take it that the exams will begin on time.

(ii) He seems to be coming round – he appears to be regaining consciousness (or changing his opinion to agree).

Sentence: The patient fainted, but after the nurse sprinkled water on his face, he seems to be coming round.

(iii) My foot's gone to sleep – my foot has become numb (lost feeling) for a while, usually after sitting in one position.

Sentence: After sitting cross-legged for two hours in the prayer meeting, my foot's gone to sleep.

II **Reported Speech: Fill in the blanks to list the changes that have occurred in the given pairs of sentences. 1. To report a question, we use the reporting verb asked (as in Sentence Set 1). 2. To report a statement, we use the reporting verb _____. 3. The adverb of place here changes to _____. 4. When the verb in direct speech is in the present tense, the verb in reported speech is in the _____ tense (as in Sentence Set 3). 5. If the verb in direct speech is in the present continuous tense, the verb in reported speech changes to _____ tense. For example, _____ changes to was getting. 6. When the sentence in direct speech contains a word denoting respect, we add the adverb _____ in the reporting clause (as in Sentence Set 1). 7. The pronouns I, me, our and mine, which are used in the first**

person in direct speech, change according to the subject or object of the reporting verb such as _____, _____, _____ or _____ in reported speech.

✔ ANSWER

1. asked (done)
2. **said** (also declared, as in Set 5)
3. **there**
4. **past** ('haven't been' becomes 'hadn't been')
5. **past continuous**; **am getting** changes to was getting
6. **respectfully**
7. **he, him, his, her** (also she / they, according to the speaker)

III **Here is an excerpt from an article from the Times of India dated 27 August 2006. Rewrite it, changing the sentences in direct speech into reported speech. Leave the other sentences unchanged. "Why do you want to know my age? If people know I am so old, I won't get work!" laughs 90-year-old A. K. Hangal, one of Hindi cinema's most famous character actors. For his age, he is rather energetic. "What's the secret?" we ask. "My intake of everything is in small quantities. And I walk a lot," he replies. "I joined the industry when people retire. I was in my 40s. So I don't miss being called a star. I am still respected and given work, when actors of my**

age are living in poverty and without work. I don't have any complaints," he says, adding, "but yes, I have always been underpaid." Recipient of the Padma Bhushan, Hangal never hankered after money or materialistic gains. "No doubt I am content today, but money is important. I was a fool not to understand the value of money earlier," he regrets.

✔ ANSWER

Ninety-year-old A. K. Hangal, one of Hindi cinema's most famous character actors, laughingly asks why we want to know his age. He says that if people know he is so old, he won't get work. For his age, he is rather energetic. We ask him what the secret is. He replies that his intake of everything is in small quantities and that he walks a lot. He says that he joined the industry when people retire. He was in his 40s, so he doesn't miss being called a star. He is still respected and given work, when actors of his age are living in poverty and without work. He says that he doesn't have any complaints, adding that he has always been underpaid. Recipient of the Padma Bhushan, Hangal never hankered after money or materialistic gains. He regrets that though, no doubt, he is content today, money is important, and that he was a fool not to understand the value of money earlier.

Note: The reporting verbs (laughs, ask, replies, says, regrets) are in the present tense, so the tenses of the reported clauses do not change; only the pronouns change (I → he, my → his, you → we).

⭐ The Proposal · Speaking and Writing

1 **Anger Management: As adults, one important thing to learn is how to manage our temper. Some of us tend to get angry quickly, while others remain calm. Can you think of three ill effects that result from anger? Note them down. Suggest ways to avoid losing your temper in such situations. Are there any benefits from anger?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Ill effects of anger:

- It harms health: high blood pressure, faster heartbeat, headache (like Lomov's palpitations).
- It spoils relationships: we say hurtful things and lose friends, as the neighbours in the play insult each other's families.
- We cannot think clearly and take wrong decisions; small matters become big quarrels.

Ways to avoid losing temper:

- Count to ten or take deep breaths before speaking.

- Walk away from the place for a while; drink water and calm down.
- Listen to the other person and try to see their point of view.
- Talk about the problem later in a calm voice; do yoga, exercise or meditation regularly.

Benefits of anger: Controlled anger can be useful. Anger against injustice can make us stand up for what is right, and it can push us to work harder and change a bad situation. But it must be expressed calmly, without hurting anyone.

2 **In pairs, prepare a script based on the given excerpt from The Home and the World by Rabindranath Tagore. You may write five exchanges between the characters with other directions such as movements on stage and way of speaking, etc.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Characters: Nikhil (the husband, a zamindar), Bimala (his wife), a Messenger

[Nikhil sits at his desk in his office, busy with papers. A messenger enters and bows.]

MESSENGER : Sir, Bimala has sent for you.

NIKHIL : [startled, looking up] Who did you say had sent for me?

MESSENGER : The Rani Mother, sir. The Chota Rani Mother.

[Nikhil rises and goes to the inner apartments. Bimala stands there, neatly dressed. He looks at her enquiringly.]

BIMALA : [flushing, playing with her bangles; then suddenly] Look here! Is it right that ours should be the only market in all Bengal which allows foreign goods?

NIKHIL : [calmly] What, then, would be the right thing to do?

BIMALA : [firmly] Order them to be cleared out!

NIKHIL : But the goods are not mine.

BIMALA : [raising her voice] Is not the market yours?

NIKHIL : It is much more theirs who use it for trade.

BIMALA : Let them trade in Indian goods, then.

NIKHIL : Nothing would please me better. But suppose they do not?

BIMALA : [angrily] Nonsense! How dare they be so insolent? Are you not...

NIKHIL : [interrupting, gently but firmly] I am very busy this afternoon and cannot stop to argue it out. But I must refuse to tyrannise.

BIMALA : It would not be tyranny for selfish gain, but for the sake of the country.

NIKHIL : [turning towards the door] To tyrannise for the country is to tyrannise over the country. But that I am afraid you will never understand.

[He walks out. Bimala stands still, upset. Lights fade.]

3 **In groups, discuss the qualities one should look for in a marriage partner. You might consider the following points. • Personal qualities – Appearance or looks – Attitudes and beliefs – Sense of humour • Value system – Compassion and kindness – Tolerance, ambition – Attitude to money and wealth • Education and professional background**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Points for discussion:

- **Personal qualities:** Looks matter less than a neat, healthy and pleasant personality. Positive attitude, similar beliefs and a good sense of humour help a couple face problems together.
- **Value system:** Honesty, compassion and kindness, respect for each other and each other's families, patience and tolerance, reasonable ambition, and a sensible (not greedy) attitude to money.
- **Education and profession:** Good education, the ability to earn and stand on one's own feet, and respect for the partner's career.

- Above all, mutual understanding, trust and the ability to settle differences calmly – unlike Lomov and Natalya, who marry for property and keep quarrelling.

4 **Are there parts of the play that remind you of film scenes from romantic comedies? Discuss this in groups, and recount to the rest of the class episodes similar to those in the play.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Points for discussion:

- The nervous hero who comes to propose but cannot say what he wants, and talks about everything else.
- The hero and heroine quarrelling over silly things (land, dogs) and then realising they want to marry each other.
- The heroine fainting/wailing "Bring him back!" and the father running to fetch the hero.
- The hero fainting, everyone thinking he is dead, and the father joining their hands in marriage when he comes round.

- Many Hindi romantic comedies show a couple who fight at first (‘tom and jerry’ type) and fall in love by the end, or a confused father caught between two quarrelling lovers. Students can recount such a scene from a film they have seen.

🎉 **Chapter 9 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**